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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1966-1974

Coverage Date: 1966-1974

Place Coverage

Kade area, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S)

Fission and fusion of the residential group

The San dislike resorting to violence; whenever possible, they try to solve disputes peacefully instead of aggravating the situation. There are no mechanisms for governing in this society; order is maintained as each individual tries to follow the proper social course according to his conscience. The most effective social principle and the one which is most vigorously observed—to the point of being almost compulsory—is the principle of sharing and cooperation. Sharing and cooperation, which lead to great interdependence, function in close relation to the kinship system. Within the concentric spreading out of kindred and joking relationships, familistic cohesion is especially strong among close kin. Within these strongly cohesive relationships, two people have a high degree of mutual permissiveness and also exhibit a high degree of sharing and cooperation. On the opposite side of the coin, as familistic cohesion weakens with increasing kin distance, the obligatoriness of sharing and cooperation also fades away. Actually, because the whole society is so small, all its members know each other at least by sight, so that even if there are dyads which do not exhibit a close kin relationship (kindred or joking relationship), the society as a whole is still based on a sufficiently strong degree of familistic cohesion. The San respect the aged, experienced, and able, and turn to them for social leadership, but decisions and solutions to problems are always based on discussion among the whole group.

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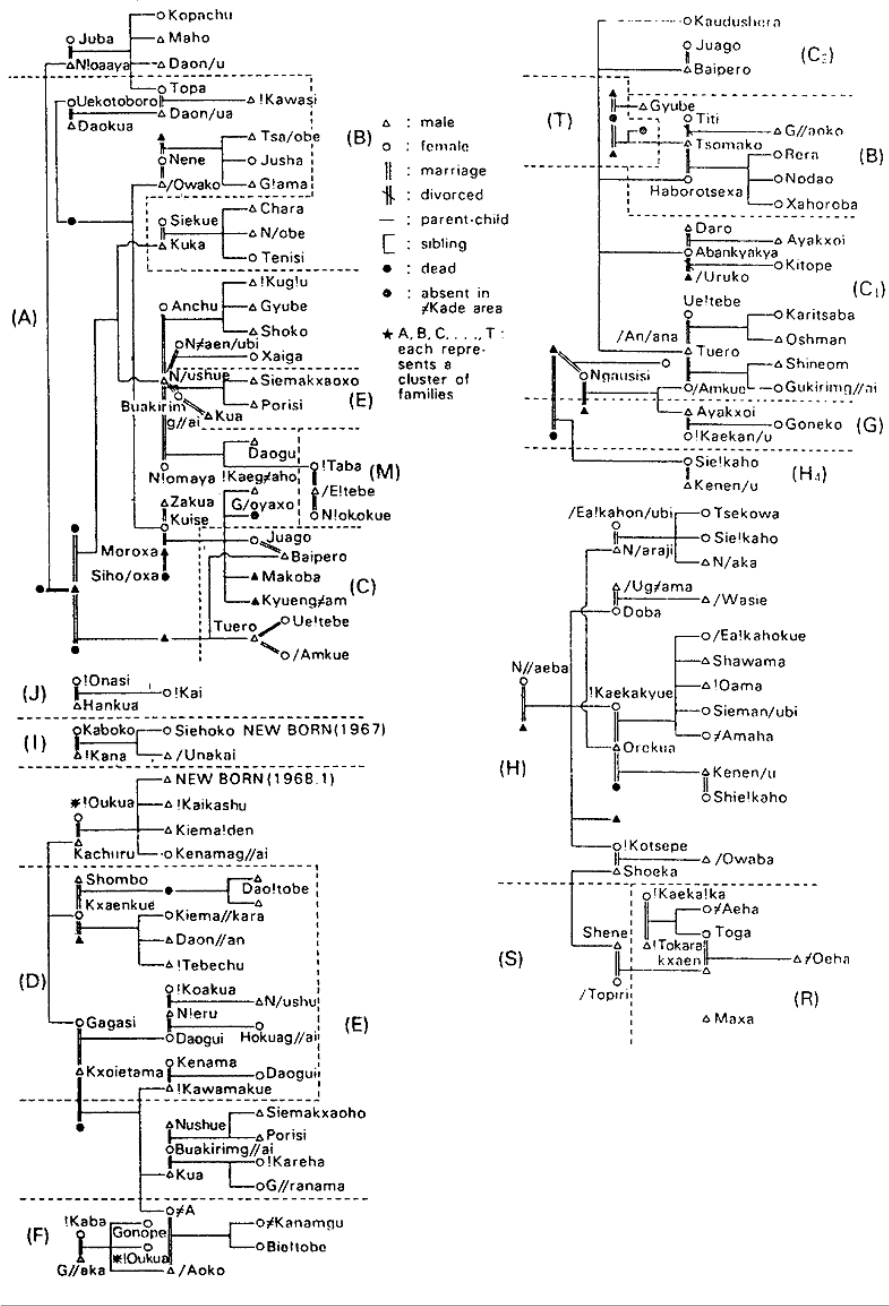
Even within the extremely egalitarian and peaceful San society, there is a constant threat of such disasters as sickness and injury and that incomprehensible phenomenon, death; the San must also confront the problems arising over food, sex, and various complications in interpersonal relations. These considerations are sufficient to keep the San and his society

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always in crisis. Through their formal dancing they drive away all the evil brought by *g//wama*—sickness, injury, starvation, drought, and death. The San depends on his conscience and self-awareness to keep him in line with social norms, and tries to follow the proper social course. When jealousy, discontent, dissension, and the like are brewing, they are dissipated within the close familistic kin relationships and joking relationships, or through amusements, such as dancing, singing, and chatting, or are otherwise sublimated into recreation. Unlike more advanced societies, however, the San's camp, consisting of only a few dozen people, brings all its members into contact day after day and forces people to continue seeing each other even if they are at odds. After a time in such a communal lifestyle, there are bound to be conflicts 124

Figure 43. Kin Relationships among the San of the ≠Kade Area



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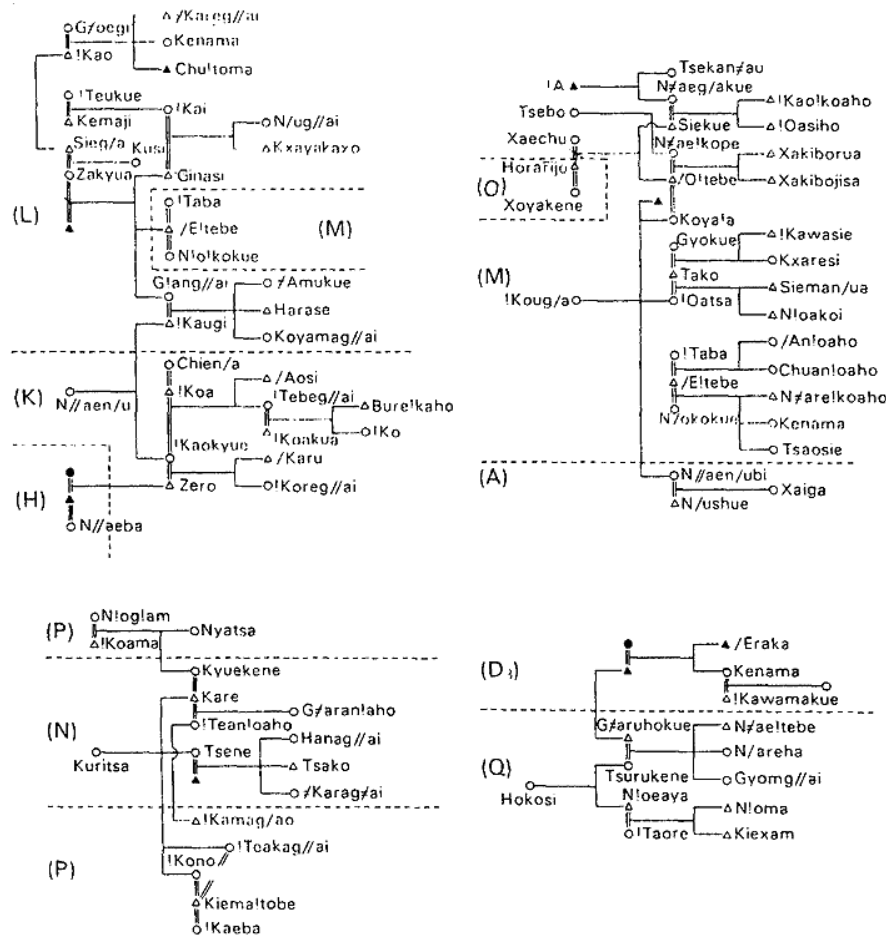
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126 that go beyond simple argument and malicious gossip. Among these conflicts, in turn, are some that are cannot be resolved through the mediation of a third person or through diversions, such as chatting or dancing. The most effective method of disposing of such cases, it seems, is through camp fission and the resulting geographical separation of the principals. I observed any number of examples in which a person would leave the camp after saying things like: "He won't share his meat with me," "He's trying to steal my woman," "I can't live any longer with a selfish person who won't share his food," "If I live together with him I'll be killed," and so forth.

Human Relations Area Files

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